

LAND OF THE JAGUAR

Central and South America

Collectively, Central and South America constitute more than 7 million sq miles (18 million sq km) of incredibly varied terrain and climate. Forming South America's backbone is the world's longest mountain range, the Andes, which at its highest point reaches almost 23,000 ft (7,000 m) above sea level. The massive lowland drainage basin of the Amazon River and its tributaries is filled with lush rainforest, and at the continent's center is the world's largest tropical wetland, the Pantanal. The south and east of South America tend to be

drier and feature highland plateaus covered with wooded savanna and wide, grassy plains. This range of habitats has resulted in a huge diversity of plant and animal species, many of them found nowhere else.

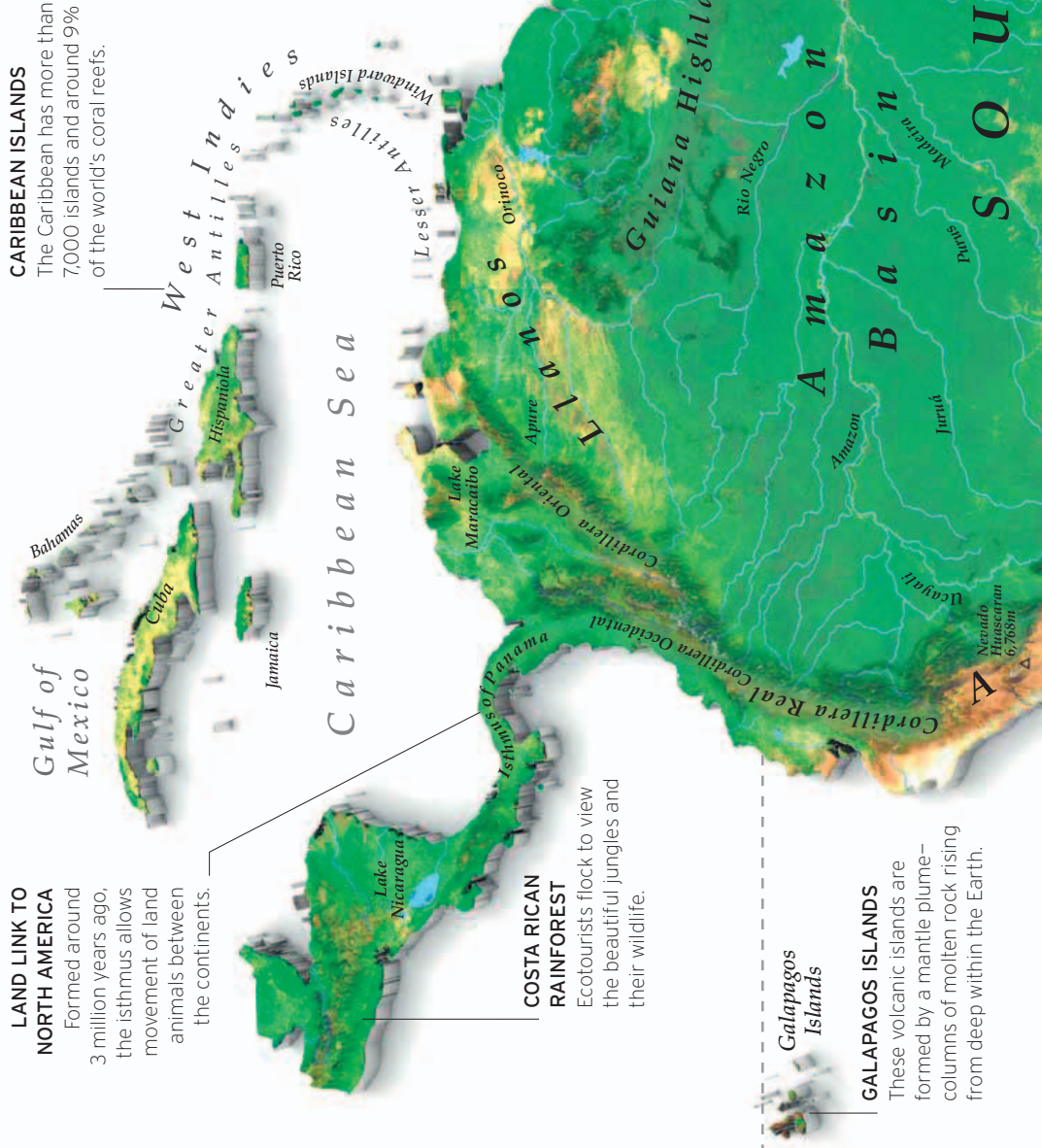
Historically, the Central American isthmus has been an important bridge for the exchange of land animals between North and South America. It is also a vital flight path for birds migrating along the Pacific Flyway between Alaska, in North America, and Patagonia, in South America.

LAND LINK TO NORTH AMERICA

Formed around 3 million years ago, the isthmus allows movement of land animals between the continents.

CARIBBEAN ISLANDS

The Caribbean has more than 7,000 islands and around 9% of the world's coral reefs.



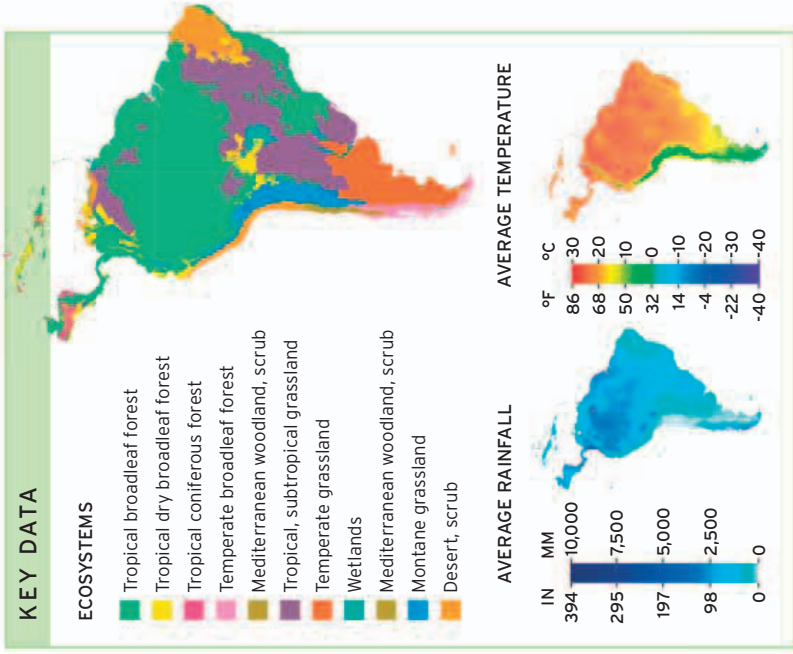
COSTA RICAN RAINFOREST

Ecotourists flock to view the beautiful jungles and their wildlife.

Galapagos Islands

GALAPAGOS ISLANDS

These volcanic islands are formed by a mantle plume—columns of molten rock rising from deep within the Earth.



AMAZON RAINFOREST



The largest rainforest on Earth dominates the northern half of South America. Estimated to be at least 55 million years old, the Amazon is home to a dazzling diversity of animal and plant life. It contains around 10 percent of the world's known species and is a refuge for jaguars, harpy eagles, and pink dolphins, as well as thousands of bird and butterfly species.

EQUATOR

ATLANTIC OCEAN

Planalto da Borborema

Tocantins

Araguaia

Serra dos Carajás

Serra do Cachimbo

Amazon

Madeira

Juruá

Ucayali

Nevado Huascarán 6,768m

Cordillera Real

Cordillera Occidental

Cordillera Oriental

Apurí

Oruro

Lake Maracaibo

Lake Nicaragua

Lesser Antilles

Greater Antilles

Windward Islands

Puerto Rico

Hispaniola

Cuba

Bahamas